

Chapter 68 Part 1

The autumn wind swept away withered branches and fallen leaves, and outside it was gloomy, as if it could rain at any moment.

Liang Shi was dazzled by Xu Qingzhu's smile. After a moment, realizing her slip of the tongue, she changed the subject, "It looks like it's going to rain again outside. Did you bring an umbrella?"

"Teacher Liang." Xu Qingzhu looked at her. "Did you hear something?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, knowing she couldn't escape the pit she'd dug for herself, so she said casually, "I was talking about myself. I'm a bit conflicted about whether or not to go find my parents."

Xu Qingzhu's gaze fixed tightly on her. After a long while, she sighed softly and said frankly, "Your own matters, you decide for yourself. But if you're trying to probe about my affairs, you can ask directly. I don't really like beating around the bush."

Liang Shi: "....."

When you were trying every possible way to probe before, I didn't see that you disliked beating around the bush!

She only grumbled quietly in her heart and didn't dare say it to Xu Qingzhu.

If she said it, she feared it would turn into another debate, and she couldn't withstand Xu Qingzhu's passive-aggressive remarks.

The main issue was that once Xu Qingzhu started being passive-aggressive, the atmosphere would always end up going in weird and strange directions.

She couldn't really handle it.

So she stubbornly said, "I really was asking about myself."

"So you do know something about what happened to me." Xu Qingzhu said, "Normally, wouldn't you first be curious that something like this also happened to me?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Trapped again.

Liang Shi looked at her and said helplessly, "Teacher Xu, the furthest road I've ever traveled in this life is the road of your schemes¹."

Xu Qingzhu zipped up her backpack, and Liang Shi smoothly picked it up before she could shoulder it.

Xu Qingzhu didn't refuse either, only smiled lightly. "I can only say that Teacher Liang is really bad at pretending."

"So... what do you think about it?" Liang Shi asked cautiously.

Since the conversation had already reached this point, if she didn't ask something, it wouldn't be worth enduring all that passive-aggressiveness.

After all, she still had a task to complete.

If she completed this task and scraped together some more, she might be able to gather enough for a down payment on a house in Haizhou City.

She couldn't help it—she had never liked renting.

She still remembered when she first earned money and wanted to buy a house, she'd shocked her agent and assistant, who all thought it was too early.

After all, entertainers spent far more time living in hotels than in their own houses, and hotels were reimbursed by the production crew. Buying a house wasn't cost-effective for her at all.

But Liang Shi said that having a house meant having a home.

She could enshrine her grandparents' ashes at home, having a place where she could rest at any time.

Even though it lacked the warmth of daily life, it was a space that belonged solely to her.

Back then, Sister Wang² said she had an obsession with buying a house.

And when she owned her own house, the feeling of satisfaction standing at the doorway was incomparable to any ordinary matter.

It was on par with the satisfaction of receiving unanimous praise after her movie was released.

Moreover, this all depended on Xu Qingzhu's attitude. If Xu Qingzhu also really wanted to know, then it would be a win-win!

Liang Shi's suppressed thoughts became active again.

Footnotes

¹ *"The furthest road I've ever traveled in this life is the road of your schemes"* - This is a play on a popular Chinese internet phrase "我走过最长的路就是你的套路" (literally "the longest road I've walked is the road of your schemes/tricks"), meaning someone has been repeatedly fooled or outmaneuvered by another person's tricks or manipulations.

² *Sister Wang* - Referring to Wang-jie (王姐), Liang Shi's agent mentioned earlier in the story. "Jie" (姐) means "older sister" and is used as a respectful form of address for women, particularly in professional settings.

Chapter 68 Part 2

"About those rumors." Liang Shi asked, "Have you ever believed them?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned and shook her head. "No."

"You're so certain?" Liang Shi was surprised. "Normally, wouldn't you have some doubts?"

"There are too many rumors in this circle, and many don't match reality. Today you walk together with someone, and the next day there might be news that you two are engaged." Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly. "Rumors stop with the wise¹."

Liang Shi: "....."

"But what if it's true?" Liang Shi said, "You'd miss out on your biological parents."

"It's fine." Xu Qingzhu said, "I have parents now."

She paused, and after fastening her seatbelt, looked at Liang Shi. "Teacher Liang, do you think we're still at an age when we need parents?"

Liang Shi's breath caught. "Huh?"

"If those rumors are true, then my father has also passed away." Xu Qingzhu said, "There's no point in me agonizing over these things. Including you—you say you want to go find your biological parents now. I'm not against it, but I can only say the results may not be satisfactory."

It was cold, and the heating was on in the car.

Xu Qingzhu rationally analyzed the current situation for her. "If what Mrs. Liang said is true, then you were abandoned. So what happens after you find them? They may already have another child, or have each formed their own families. Your appearance might make them feel awkward. If their financial situation is good, their children might worry you'll divide the family assets. If their financial situation isn't good, you might have to support them. The best outcome is actually finding them, but everyone being well in their own lives."

Liang Shi: "....."

She had to admit, what Xu Qingzhu said made a lot of sense.

Although it was somewhat cold.

Actually, for Liang Shi, she had never had the thought of finding her biological parents.

The reasons were similar to what Xu Qingzhu said.

They had indeed passed the age when they needed parents to give them love, so there was no need to be fixated on it.

If they naturally found them, then they'd acknowledge the relationship.

If the other party was unwilling, then they'd treat it as if there was nothing.

Anyway, they'd made it through so many storms and trials over the years. There was no need to create more trouble for themselves because of this kind of thing.

Liang Shi nodded, agreeing with her statement. "Teacher Xu, I think the same way."

Xu Qingzhu found a cushion to pad against the car window and leaned lightly against it to rest. "That's pretty good then."

Liang Shi hesitated for a moment, then said again, "You just said if I was curious about your affairs, I could ask directly, right?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu said, "But I may not necessarily answer."

Since Xu Qingzhu said so, Liang Shi's courage grew a bit more, but she confirmed with her again. "I can ask whatever I want, and you won't get angry, right?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned, as if in disbelief. "You're not going to ask some idiotic question, are you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"That depends on what your standard for 'idiotic' is." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: ".....It better be worth answering."

After thinking, Liang Shi decided to ask anyway.

"Haven't you thought about getting a DNA test?" Liang Shi asked, "The results come out in two hours. Why keep guessing back and forth?"

"I'm not guessing." Xu Qingzhu said matter-of-factly, "You're the one who's curious. I've basically never been curious about it."

Liang Shi: "?"

In that instant, she felt that Xu Qingzhu's rationality might exceed her imagination.

Could there really be someone in this world who could suppress their curiosity like this?

Liang Shi considered herself not someone with very strong curiosity. In the past, everyone thought she was so laid-back she didn't seem human.

But after coming here, her worldview had been refreshed again and again, and she'd become curious about all sorts of things.

Her life was like a puzzle missing many pieces.

At first it was fine—she could convince herself not to care about it.

But now, as more and more puzzle pieces appeared, it was like having obsessive-compulsive disorder. She had to complete this puzzle, so she kept digging for the truth.

She simply couldn't suppress her curiosity anymore.

But Xu Qingzhu could actually suppress it in this kind of matter.

Liang Shi's astonished expression was too obvious, making Xu Qingzhu chuckle softly. "Very surprised?"

Liang Shi nodded frantically.

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice rang out in the car. "When I was young, my grandparents would often mention my uncle. They would occasionally complain that he had no sense of responsibility and wouldn't inherit the family business. Occasionally when they thought of him, they would shed tears and cherish his memory. But to me, he was just a name. I'd never met him. Even after my grandparents passed away, our family didn't have a single photo of my uncle."

"Every year, my mom would take us to pay respects at my uncle's grave, and she would say she was taking good care of us, with special emphasis on me." Xu Qingzhu said, "And my parents are the best choice for me."

She looked at Liang Shi. "A person has two sets of parents in their life—one set that gave birth to you, and another set that raised you. Comparatively, I recognize the latter. And since they all chose to keep it from me, it shows they don't want me to know. My childhood was happy, and my growth process went smoothly. There's no need to be curious about this kind of thing and make everyone uncomfortable."

Liang Shi: "....."

This hit Liang Shi right in the heart.

In an instant, her perspective broadened!

Liang Shi had previously thought Xu Qingzhu didn't know, but actually Xu Qingzhu just didn't want to pierce through it.

The people who loved her had woven a mirage² for her, so she stayed within that mirage.

Xu Qingzhu wasn't curious, so she didn't believe the rumors and didn't investigate.

"What about your aunt?" Liang Shi asked again, "You've never been curious about her either?"

"My uncle never married in his life. There was only one girlfriend whose name was known, and she disappeared after my uncle passed away." Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "Where would I have an aunt?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She was the narrow-minded one.

She suddenly understood that this 1.3 million was a pit dug by the system.

It was impossible to get.

Damn system!

Liang Shi cursed silently in her heart.

Footnotes

¹ *"Rumors stop with the wise"* - This is a Chinese proverb "谣言止于智者" (yáoyán zhǐ yú zhìzhě), meaning that wise or intelligent people don't believe or spread rumors, thus stopping their circulation.

² *Mirage* - The Chinese term used is "海市蜃楼" (hǎishì shènlóu), which literally means "sea market mirage" and refers to an optical illusion or something beautiful but illusory and unattainable. Here it metaphorically represents the beautiful but potentially false reality Xu Qingzhu's family created for her.

Chapter 68 Part 3

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Liang Shi had brought Xu Qingya to the Xu family home once before, so this time she knew the way well.

After they arrived, they didn't go into the house yet, but went to the cemetery together first.

The cemetery was in the suburbs, in the same direction as coming from Qianshui Bay to the Xu family home. It was about half an hour's drive.

The climate in the suburbs was different from the city—the humidity was higher, and fine, dense rain threads were drifting down.

Liang Shi followed the Xu family's car the whole way. After arriving, she got out first to open her umbrella, then went to the passenger side to receive Xu Qingzhu.

As a result, she saw Xu Qingzhu pull out a folding umbrella from her backpack, revealing just an edge of it.

She moved her umbrella farther away, but then Xu Qingzhu directly placed her backpack in the back seat without taking anything out, and got out of the car on her own.

Liang Shi immediately held the umbrella over her.

Xu Qingya was holding a small blue umbrella by herself, standing in the rain looking at the two of them. "You two only brought one umbrella?"

Xu Qingzhu replied without changing her expression, "Mm."

Liang Shi: "?"

She began to suspect she had seen wrong.

However, this was just a small episode.

After entering the cemetery, they still had to walk quite a distance. Xu Guangyao and Sheng Linlang also shared one umbrella. Xu Guangyao's tall and large frame made Sheng Linlang appear even more frail.

For some reason, looking at them from behind, Liang Shi inexplicably felt that Sheng Linlang's back looked desolate.

In this world, the people with direct blood relations to her seemed to be only her two daughters left.

Her parents had fallen ill from worry over their only younger brother and passed away early.

Only she was left to support the enormous Sheng family.

Actually, thinking about it carefully, one could understand. Over these many years, although Xu Guangyao wasn't talented at business, he had indeed been good to Sheng Linlang and their two daughters. He might have some inherent character flaws, such as arrogance and stubbornness that couldn't be changed, but he was a qualified father who did everything for his daughters' sake.

Back when Sheng Linlang had shouldered such a huge burden, it had always been Xu Guangyao by her side accompanying her.

Liang Shi suddenly felt that Sheng Linlang was a very intelligent woman.

When Sheng Linlang was young, she was beautiful. Calling her Haizhou City's number one beauty would not be an exaggeration. Many talented young men and beautiful women came to pursue her, but she chose Xu Guangyao.

Because she knew that people couldn't remain beautiful forever, and those who came for the Sheng family and her beauty might very well have affairs after she grew old and lost her looks, or swallow up the Sheng family, especially those whose own family businesses were also doing well.

No one could refuse the piece of cake that was the Sheng family.

Perhaps many people had ridiculed Sheng Linlang for being foolish back then, but for Sheng Linlang, she had made a decision that wasn't wrong.

At least both daughters were raised very well.

The cemetery was very large. Buried here were the Sheng family parents, and also Sheng Qinglin.

Sheng Linlang placed the flowers she brought in front of Sheng Qinglin's grave. The fine rain threads made everything seem desolate yet peaceful.

After a long while, Sheng Linlang called Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu over. Like a family matriarch, she introduced them to Sheng Qinglin in a low voice. "Qinglin, this is Liang Shi, Qingzhu's wife. She's pretty, right? Just as pretty as our Qingzhu."

"She's also a very good person, and Qingzhu likes her very much. They didn't come to see you when they got married before, but now you've met her, so it can be considered fulfilling a wish." After introducing Liang Shi, Sheng Linlang called Xu Qingya over and nagged a few words about her grades, even saying Xu Qingya wasn't like her uncle at all—not clever.

Xu Qingya pouted but didn't argue back.

Although her grades were first in the entire grade.

But everyone in the Xu family knew that there were three days in the year when you absolutely couldn't provoke Sheng Linlang—the death anniversaries of the Sheng family parents and Sheng Qinglin's death anniversary.

Otherwise, their mother would seem like a different person, either crying endlessly or losing her temper.

Over so many years, this had become an unspoken "rule" of the Sheng family.

After paying respects to Sheng Qinglin, they stood for a while in front of the Sheng family parents' graves.

Liang Shi stood there observing a moment of silence for a few minutes. When she raised her head, her gaze casually swept around, and she discovered a black figure.

Just a back view, but it gave Liang Shi an unusually familiar feeling.

The person was wearing a black qipao¹, walking step by step toward the cemetery exit, swaying gracefully.

Liang Shi immediately tugged at Xu Qingzhu, gesturing for her to look in that direction. Xu Qingzhu's eyes immediately widened, and she mouthed to her: "Yang Jiani?"

Liang Shi nodded.

They watched Yang Jiani's figure disappear into the cemetery.

The conclusions they'd deduced last night seemed to be right before their eyes, ready to be verified.

When Xu Guangyao and the others were preparing to leave, Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked, "Mom and Dad, do you know President Qi from Qida Company? That person who's famously devoted to his family."

Xu Guangyao frowned upon hearing this. "What's wrong?"

"Just asking casually." Xu Qingzhu didn't mention Liang Shi's affairs, and casually made up an excuse. "I met his wife recently, and I feel that President Qi isn't as simple as he appears on the surface."

"Is it Jiani?" Sheng Linlang suddenly asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Right, right, right. His wife is called Yang Jiani. Mom, do you know her?"

In the bleak rain, a gust of autumn wind swept past, making people shiver from the cold.

The rain was getting heavier. Liang Shi tilted the umbrella more toward Xu Qingzhu's side, leaving half of her own shoulder exposed outside, but Xu Qingzhu imperceptibly leaned closer to her, then placed her hand on Liang Shi's wrist, straightening the umbrella's direction.

Sheng Linlang slowly nodded. "We were very close when we were young."

"What kind of person is she?" Xu Qingzhu asked, "Are you still in contact now?"

Sheng Linlang shook her head. "After her family went bankrupt, she stopped contacting us."

Xu Qingzhu frowned. "Haven't you seen her since then?"

Sheng Linlang glanced at the cemetery. "Every Qingming Festival², I put a bouquet of flowers in front of her parents' grave. Her parents are also buried in this cemetery."

"When is their death anniversary?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Sheng Linlang said, "March."

Xu Qingzhu asked which area Yang Jiani's parents' graves were in, then planned to go look with Liang Shi in a bit.

After a while, Sheng Linlang suddenly said, "One year she called me in the middle of the night, saying she'd gone crazy, and also saying her daughter had died."

Sheng Linlang shook her head on her own. "But she hung up after just a few words. When I called her back, she didn't answer. Later when she did answer, she told me not to contact her anymore, so we haven't been in contact since."

"When was that?" Xu Qingzhu continued asking.

Sheng Linlang thought carefully. "Around when you were nine, I think. Back then you were getting sick every few days, and I couldn't spare attention for her. When she called me, you were still running a fever..."

Xu Qingzhu fell silent. "I see."

Footnotes

¹ *Qipao* - Also known as cheongsam, a traditional Chinese dress characterized by a high collar, fitted bodice, and side slits. It's a form-fitting one-piece dress that became popular in the 1920s and remains an iconic garment in Chinese culture.

² *Qingming Festival* - Also known as Tomb-Sweeping Day, this is a traditional Chinese festival usually occurring around April 4-6, when families visit the graves of their ancestors to clean the tombstones, pray, and make ritual offerings.

Chapter 68 Part 4

Sheng Linlang hadn't socialized or attended business functions for a long time. At home, she had nothing to do but copy Buddhist scriptures and read books. Occasionally she'd go out shopping to buy things for her husband and daughters, not concerning herself with worldly affairs.

Even when the company was on the verge of bankruptcy, her heart remained unperturbed. She felt that at worst they could just live a hard life.

After her parents and younger brother passed away, she began cultivating her body and mind.

Especially since her eldest daughter had been kidnapped when she was young, and afterward fell ill every few days—fate didn't seem to be very kind to her.

After Xu Guangyao and the others left, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu went to the place Sheng Linlang had mentioned.

It was also in the direction Yang Jiani had left.

When they arrived, there were fresh flowers placed in front of the two elders' tombstone.

It seemed Yang Jiani had indeed come to pay respects to her parents, but... it wasn't a holiday, wasn't New Year's, and wasn't their death anniversary either. Why would she suddenly come?

Liang Shi felt something wasn't quite right, so she walked around the area and discovered that another tombstone in the same row, separated by four graves, also had fresh flowers in front of it.

But this tombstone was rather special—it was an unmarked grave.

The flowers were baby's breath¹, purple and yellow baby's breath that looked especially clean and pure after being washed by the rain.

"An unmarked grave." Liang Shi guessed in a low voice, "Did Yang Jiani place these?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "Not sure."

But she felt it was very likely.

Given Yang Jiani's pathological obsession with Qi Jiao, if Qi Jiao had died, she couldn't possibly not bury her.

But there was still a Qi Jiao alive now, so it was also impossible to erect a tombstone. So there was a very high possibility she would set up an unmarked grave for her.

At the same time, burying her in the same cemetery as her parents, each time using the excuse of paying respects to her parents when she was actually paying respects to her daughter.

"So what special day is today?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly raised an eyebrow. "Perhaps we can ask Rainbow?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi felt this was a good idea.

So she stood there and called Zhou Li, then asked for Rainbow to take the call.

Liang Shi asked very tactfully, "Rainbow, do you know if today is some important day for Teacher Qi?"

Rainbow flipped through a calendar. "It's her birthday, the lunar calendar one."

Liang Shi felt this made everything clear. After exchanging pleasantries with Rainbow for a few sentences, she ended up being teased by Rainbow. "Sister Liang, you're so fake."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I'm just a tool person²." Rainbow said.

Liang Shi: "....."

For a little kid to have such a trendy self-awareness of her own positioning.

And what she said today wasn't even wrong. Liang Shi could only say helplessly, "I'll treat you to something delicious another day."

Rainbow haggled with her. "Can you bring just me alone?"

"Sure." Liang Shi agreed.

After hanging up, Liang Shi checked the date. It was the end of the eighth lunar month.

She made a note of the date, then bowed in front of the tombstone before preparing to leave with Xu Qingzhu.

But on their way out of the cemetery, they passed by a mother and daughter.

Having just seen what might be Qi Jiao's grave, Liang Shi was feeling down. The umbrella was held very low, and she was in no mood to look at her surroundings.

So it was just a simple passing by.

Footnotes

¹ *Baby's breath* - Known in Chinese as "满天星" (mǎntiānxīng), literally "stars filling the sky." These are small, delicate flowers (*Gypsophila*) commonly used as filler in bouquets. They symbolize everlasting love, purity, and innocence.

² *Tool person* - "工具人" (gōngjùrén) is a modern Chinese internet slang term referring to someone who is used by others only when needed for a specific purpose, like a tool, and is otherwise ignored or unvalued. It's similar to being used or taken advantage of.

Chapter 68 Part 5

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The woman was wearing a black trench coat with a white shirt and black high-waisted long pants underneath. Her hair was casually tied up, and she was still wearing sunglasses. With one hand she held the little child, and with the other she held a large black umbrella.

The little child was also dressed all in black, obediently following the woman as they walked into the cemetery, then continued forward until they stopped in front of a tombstone with fresh flowers placed before it.

The woman took off her sunglasses, revealing one lifeless eye.

She crouched down halfway, took out the flowers and placed them in front of the tombstone, then looked at the person in the photo. Tears formed into pearls and fell.

The little child immediately moved closer to her, reaching out to wipe her tears. "Mommy, don't cry."

"Mommy is fine." The woman said, "I just miss your daddy a little."

The little child pressed her lips together, probably not yet understanding what it all meant.

To her, she hadn't seen her daddy since she was born.

She also didn't know what it felt like to suddenly not have a daddy.

She just felt sorry for her mommy.

"Sheng Yu, bow to your daddy." The woman wiped away her tears and said gently, "Introduce yourself to daddy, and your summary too."

Sheng Yu looked at the photo on the tombstone and said in a low voice, "Mommy, why is this photo in black and white? It doesn't look as good as the ones we have at home."

Su Yao's tears fell again in a rush, but she still patiently explained to Sheng Yu, "This is daddy's posthumous photo¹, but this picture was taken when daddy graduated from university. It's his graduation photo."

It had just been edited to black and white tones.

Sheng Yu seemed to understand and oh-ed, then faced the tombstone directly. Her crisp voice rang out: "Hello daddy, I'm Sheng Yu. I'm five years old this year, and this is my first time coming to see you. I was so curious about what you looked like, but mommy said I can never see you again, because you're in another world. So you have to be well in that other world, okay? Don't get sick, and don't be sad. Most importantly, can you bless mommy and stop her from crying anymore?"

"Also." Sheng Yu paused, puffing out her cheeks. "When I go to the other world in the future, will I be able to see you?"

Su Yao crouched in front of the tombstone. The large black umbrella enveloped her and Sheng Yu's figures, as if isolating them in a small world of their own.

She looked at the photo on the tombstone and suddenly smiled bitterly. "Even though I've already cried until one eye went blind for you, why do I still cry when I see your photo?"

"Sheng Qinglin." Su Yao called this name tenderly and affectionately. "You have to be well over there, okay? I've been dreaming about you a lot lately. Are you missing me?"

Su Yao shook her head on her own. "But I won't go keep you company. I have to take care of Sheng Yu until she grows up."

"Do you still remember? We used to dream about it—if we had a daughter in the future, we'd name her Sheng Yu. Although this promise came many years late, I've still fulfilled it." Su Yao said, "This is the bloodline I risked my life to keep for you. I almost went to find you in the delivery room."

"But you seemed quite prescient—you froze sperm abroad. Look, your daughter looks so much like you."

Su Yao crouched there, chattering on: "But I always feel like I've forgotten something. Big Brother² says that recovering to my current state is already very remarkable—I can still remember you, and I can still raise Sheng Yu."

"But I always feel like I've forgotten some important person, some important thing. Sometimes I'll cry for no reason when I'm spacing out. If you can hear me, can you tell me what exactly I've forgotten?"

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Footnotes

¹ *Posthumous photo* - "遗照" (yízhào) refers to a photograph of a deceased person displayed at funerals or placed on graves. In Chinese tradition, these are typically formal photos converted to black and white or sepia tones to indicate the person has passed away.

² *Big Brother* - "大哥" (dàgē) is a respectful term used to address an older male, either an actual older brother, an older male cousin, or sometimes a senior male friend or mentor. Given the context, this likely refers to Su Yao's older brother or a close male relative/friend who has been helping take care of her.

Chapter 68 Part 6

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One of Xu Qingzhu's bracelets had been left behind at the cemetery.

The car had already driven several hundred meters away when Xu Qingzhu discovered it, so Liang Shi drove back to accompany her to retrieve it.

Then they saw a woman in a black trench coat holding an umbrella, sheltering herself and a child underneath it. The two were crouched in front of Sheng Qinglin's grave.

They were too far away, and with the rain falling, they couldn't hear what was being said at all.

But Xu Qingzhu stood there with a wooden expression.

Through the silhouettes, Liang Shi roughly guessed who this was.

It was Su Yao and Su Yu.

But she didn't proactively tell Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu didn't ask either. She just calmly watched this scene.

"Should we... go over and take a look?" Liang Shi asked tentatively.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head, her voice very soft. "No need."

She didn't say anything, but her eyes were very complex.

Liang Shi knew she would need time to digest this matter.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu moved her somewhat stiff body, as if giving herself enough courage. But as she was about to walk over, she asked Liang Shi, "Someone who might be my aunt has appeared. It's okay for me to go over and ask, right?"

Liang Shi reached out and grasped her hand.

Xu Qingzhu's hand was originally cold, but now it was even colder, like an ice block.

Liang Shi's hand wrapped around hers as she firmly nodded at her. "Of course you can. I'm still right here beside you. Teacher Xu, let's go."

As she spoke, she was about to pull her over, but Xu Qingzhu couldn't move her feet.

Xu Qingzhu's hand was trembling. Although she was tightly gripping Liang Shi's hand, she pulled back. "But she has a new child. Should I really disturb their peaceful life?"

Liang Shi comforted her. "Why would you? You're just going to ask, or just meet them."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head, her feet stepping backward. She smiled bitterly. "Forget it. She might just be my uncle's friend."

Xu Qingzhu let out a light breath, trying to calm her thoughts as much as possible. "Let's go, let's go home."

But Liang Shi looked at her. "Teacher Xu, you were speaking so confidently just now? How did you become a coward now? We're just going to look. Besides, I've met that little child before. We're just saying hello, it's not some big deal."

Xu Qingzhu looked up at her, her eyes watery, asking in a trembling voice, "Is it that Sheng Yu?"

Liang Shi nodded. "She's Rainbow's classmate. I'm going to greet a classmate's parent."

Xu Qingzhu still shook her head. She closed her eyes. "Liang Shi, don't."

Liang Shi looked at her, seeming to understand why she was wavering.

The truth seemed to be just one step away.

But Xu Qingzhu was resisting.

Before seeing the person, she could speak confidently, but after seeing them, she suddenly became timid.

The string that had been taut in her heart suddenly snapped.

The beliefs she had always held onto collapsed with a roar. This was probably an extremely sorrowful thing.

Liang Shi let out a light breath. Seeing her drifting, unstable emotions, she suddenly understood why the system said when issuing the task that Xu Qingzhu might develop PTSD from learning about her biological parents.

Now she no longer had her usual composure, nor the confidence she'd shown when communicating with her on the way here.

All she had were slightly trembling legs and ice-cold hands.

Liang Shi squeezed her hand, mainly pressing on the area of her tiger's mouth¹, giving her a gentle massage, trying to help her relieve tension and anxiety.

"Then we won't go." Liang Shi said, "Let's go home. I'll come back tomorrow to get your bracelet for you."

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Let's go."

But her legs were weak, and she seemed unable to put strength into walking.

Liang Shi supported her, but after taking one step, Xu Qingzhu stopped again. She turned her body, and suddenly half of her body fell into the curtain of rain.

Then she gazed far off in the direction of that black umbrella.

Liang Shi supported her arm, saying gently, "Xu Qingzhu, let's go. Stop looking."

But Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked, "Do you think she still remembers that she once gave birth to a daughter?"

Liang Shi heard the slight crying tone in her voice, and her heart suddenly ached.

As if something had tugged at it.

Xu Qingzhu was so clever. She could easily connect all the clues together.

Even those few probing sentences Liang Shi had intentionally or unintentionally said.

It was just a kindergarten child mentioned a few days ago. This name was like so many ordinary names, nothing special about it.

But for Xu Qingzhu, she remembered it clearly.

Ling Dang said Sheng Yu's mother looked a lot like her.

Liang Shi had also tested her before the grave visit, whether she would go looking for her biological parents.

All the clues pointed in a very obvious direction.

Now Xu Qingzhu only needed to walk forward a few steps, go over and see that woman's face clearly, see what that little child looked like.

But her heart was pounding wildly.

People always seemed to be like this.

Reason and emotion pulled at each other to the extreme, forever wavering.

Liang Shi patted her shoulder, coaxing her like a little child. "Our Zhuzhu² has parents, so whether she remembers or not, what does it matter?"

Xu Qingzhu looked up at her, her eyes reddening.

She sniffled, her cool voice carrying a hint of complaint. "Teacher Liang, the wind is so strong here."

"Then I'll take you away." Liang Shi said.

As soon as her words fell, the mother and daughter pair had already stood up and were walking in their direction, holding their umbrella.

The wide umbrella brim obscured the woman's face. The exquisitely carved little child wore a mask, but those eyes were bright and lively, with the same eye shape as Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu only looked once. As they were about to approach, Xu Qingzhu instinctively tugged at Liang Shi's wrist, pressing the umbrella low. Rain from the umbrella's edge fell along the ribs onto the ground.

Drip, drip—

Xu Qingzhu directly stood on her tiptoes, taking advantage of the momentum to pull down Liang Shi's collar.

The distance between the two became extremely close. She closed her eyes, her breath falling on Liang Shi's face.

Xu Qingzhu's eyelashes kept trembling. The moment she closed her eyes, tears fell.

And her trembling lips landed lightly on Liang Shi's lips.

As if she had found all her support.

Footnotes

¹ *Tiger's mouth* - "虎口" (hǔkǒu) refers to the fleshy area between the thumb and index finger. In traditional Chinese medicine, this acupressure point is believed to help relieve stress, headaches, and anxiety when massaged.

² *Zhuzhu* - "竹子" (zhúzi) literally means "bamboo," but here it's being used as an affectionate nickname derived from Xu Qingzhu's name (清竹 contains the character 竹 meaning bamboo). Using "our Zhuzhu" (咱们竹子) shows Liang Shi speaking tenderly and protectively, like addressing a child or loved one.